



Above The Church of St. George, Lalibela, is carved in the form of a Greek cross, from an excavation 40 ft (12 m) deep

A Day in Lalibela

Lalibela's lovely churches can be split into three main groups: the first two, the Northern and Eastern Groups (conveniently containing some of the town's most impressive and important) lie with a short distance of downtown; the third group lies scattered outside town. For a tour of the churches, visit the tiny Tourist Office, where you can find a guide and the informative pamphlet *Lalibela: World Heritage*.

MORNING Visit the Northern and Eastern Groups of churches. The two most impressive are **Bet Giyorgis** (The Church of St. George), considered the most perfect of all the churches, and **Bet Medhane Alem**, which measures 110 ft x 77 ft (33.5 x 23.5 m), and is believed to be the largest rock-hewn church in the world. Other highlights of the Northern Group include **Bet Golgotha** and **Bet Mikael**. In the Eastern Group, don't miss **Bet Amanuel** and **Bet Abba Libanos**.

AFTERNOON Consider a trip to one of the churches outside the town. Particularly recommended are **Yemrehanna Kristos**, **Ashetan Maryam**, and **Na'akuto La'ab**.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Lalibela has a domestic **airport** 14 miles (23 km) south of town and there are **minibus taxis** to the downtown. There is a daily **bus** from Addis-Ababa, which takes two days to reach Lalibela.

WHERE TO STAY

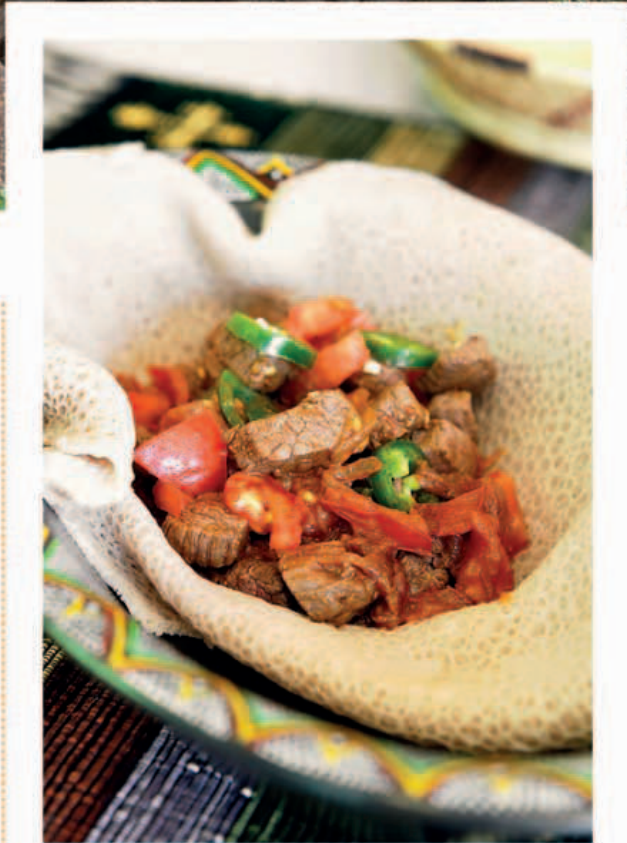
Seven Olives Hotel (inexpensive) has simple but peaceful rooms with views across lovely gardens. +251 3 3336 0020

Tukol Village (moderate) offers the option of staying overnight in a *tukul* (traditional Ethiopian hut). +251 3 3336 0564

Yemereha Hotel (moderate) has comfortable rooms furnished with traditional Ethiopian crafts. www.greenlandethiopia.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

Main Lalibela road (near St. Lalibela Secondary School); +251 3 3336 0167



Above *Injera* forms the base for *seg wat*, a spicy meat stew that traditionally uses *beri-beri*, a very hot Ethiopian chili pepper